Chapter Twenty-Three

The Gempei War

In Japan, between 1179 and 1185,
the Taira clan is laid waste,
and the rule of the shoguns begins

IN THE TWO DECADES since the Heiji Disturbance, Taira Kiyomori had been steadily rising through the ranks of Japanese courtiers.

He was helped out by the Cloistered Emperor Go-Shirakawa, who needed the support of Kiyomori and his samurai to keep his power over the increasingly rebellious Emperor Nijo. With Go-Shirakawa's support, Kiyomori became in turn a member of the State Council, Captain of the Palace Guards, Chief of the Central Police, and finally Prime Minister. His brother Yorimori became the Cloistered Emperor's chancellor, his son Shigemori military commander of the capital city. When the Emperor Nijo died of a sudden illness at the age of twenty-two, Kiyomori arranged a marriage between his own daughter Tokuko and Nijo's successor, the Emperor Takakura (Nijo's younger half brother). The imperial offices were falling, one by one, under Taira control.[1]

Go-Shirakawa's scheme to boost Taira power had succeeded too well, and by 1179 the Cloistered Emperor found power slipping from his hands. He needed to check Taira ambitions; and so he intervened sharply in Kiyomori's affairs, confiscating land that Kiyomori had commandeered and returning it to its original Fujiwara and Minamoto rulers.

He believed that the time was ripe to bring the Taira crashing down, but he was wrong. Kiyomori could still raise a larger samurai force than any of